THE HINDU
Sunday, November 1, 2026

magazine



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15 years of the Dharamshala International Film Festival

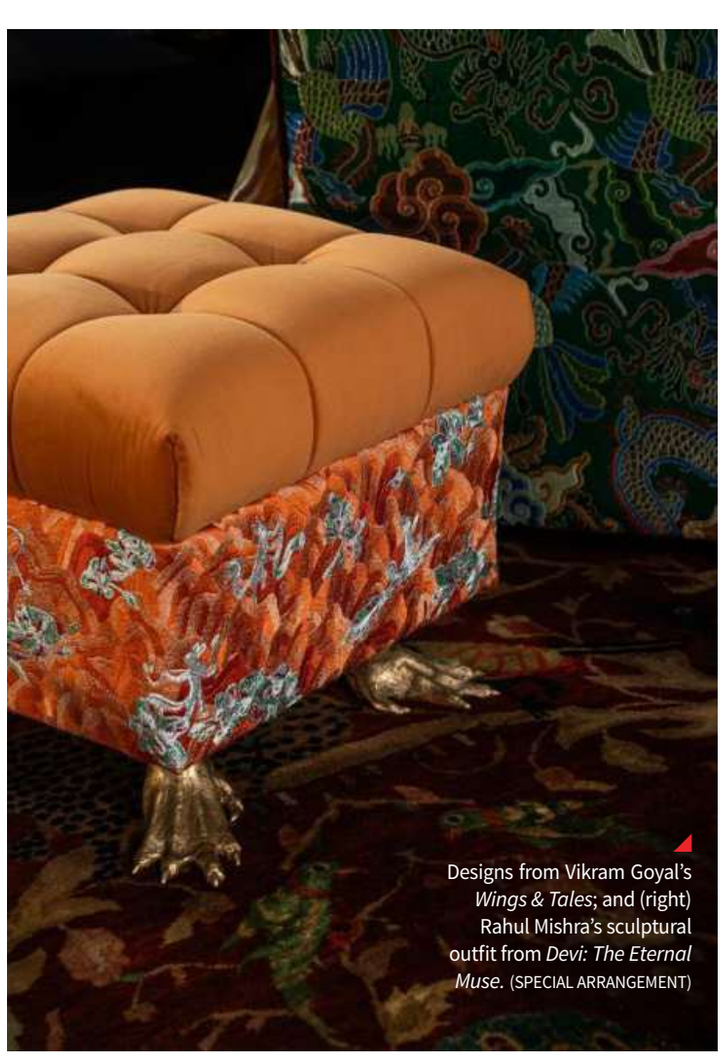
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LITERARY REVIEW

How novelist Elif Shafak found a friend in Flaubert

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Designs from Vikram Goyal's *Wings & Tales*; and (right) Rahul Mishra's sculptural outfit from *Devi: The Eternal Muse.* (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

GODS ARE BACK IN FASHION

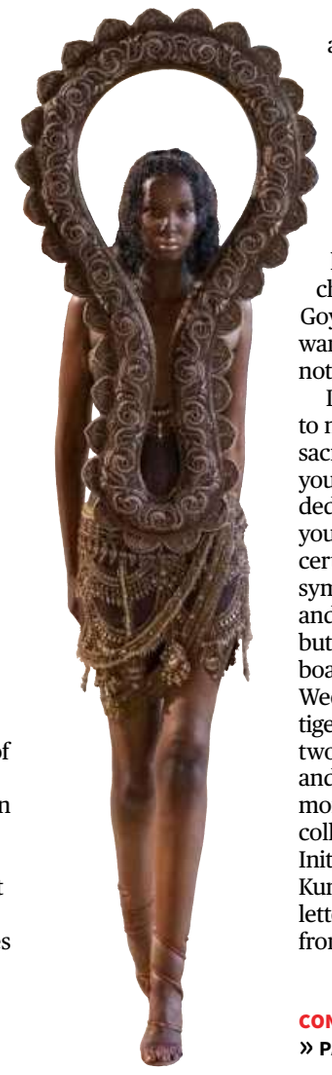
Hindu deities and epic tales such as the *Ramayana* are finding new life in India's art and design

Arman Khan

In the fairgrounds of Delhi's Ramlila Maidan on Dussehra, you can't help but be a believer. It is a gloriously unpolished affair: tinsel crowns and cardboard chariots lit by harsh floodlights. It is a story that has been retold across the country since forever, and yet, each time one witnesses any version of the *Ramayana*, it is just as relevant with its universal theme of the victory of good over evil.

But for artist Vikram Goyal, the world of the *Ramayana* was rarely about its star characters. He trained his eyes, instead, on the other mortals. Jatayu, the demigod vulture; Garuda, the heroic eagle; Sushena, the monkey physician. Goyal felt that no one seemed to notice how central they were to the story, or the many themes of sacrifice and loyalty they embodied.

Last month, *Wings & Tales*, Goyal's first solo show in London, was staged as a *baithak* (gathering) during the annual art and design fairs, Frieze and PAD. He filled a Mayfair townhouse with repoussé furniture, brocade, carpets and mother-of-pearl pieces inspired by the animals and birds of the *Ramayana*. "Where else would you see Jatayu and [hundreds of] monkeys in one story but in the *Ramayana*? It left an indelible impression on me as a child," explains the founder of Vikram Goyal Studio. "[With the collection] I wanted to explore how we, as humans, are not the only beings in the world."



Indian mythmaking can be tricky terrain to navigate. There is always the fear of sacrilege, of saying too much or too little. If you portray a goddess inaccurately, a group dedicated to her might put a bounty on your head. If you lean too heavily on certain themes, you might be seen as sympathising with a political party. Cinema and art have long taken on this challenge, but of late design and fashion are getting on board, too. At the recent Lakmé Fashion Week, mythical creatures – from Yali, part tiger part elephant, to Bherunda, the two-headed bird – popped up on jackets and shirts by fashion label Day & Age. Last month, 'The Ramayana' typeface, a collaboration between The Typecraft Initiative and Madhubani artists Pushpa Kumari and Pradyumna Kumar – with letters representing different characters from the epic – was released.

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Turkish-British writer Elif Shafak says she found a kindred spirit in French novelist Gustave Flaubert.

IN CONVERSATION

STUCK IN THE 19TH CENTURY

Our turbulent times stem from what began in the past, says Elif Shafak, whose new novel is a fictional biography of Gustave Flaubert

Kanika Sharma

At a time when our existence seems reduced to a data point, the words of Turkish-British writer Elif Shafak feel diaphanous, allowing thoughts and emotions to expand into something more. Sometimes, they take the form of a colour, an image or a taste that refuses to disappear. They leave an imprint on the page, making space for human endeavour. Yet, lately, words have also become seeds of divisiveness, usurped by AI and deployed as instruments of distraction.

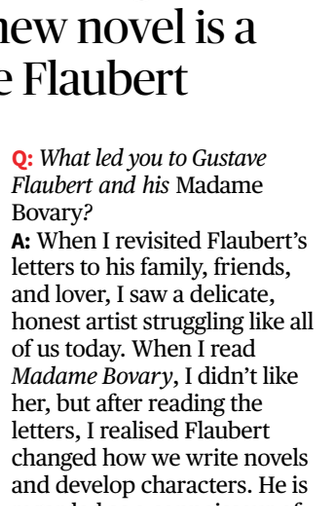
When Shafak found herself in despair, she turned to literature in search of a kindred spirit and found one in Gustave Flaubert. Born more than two centuries ago, the French novelist is regarded as a pioneer of realism who gave voice to society's pariahs. In her latest book, *In One Brief Moment All Eternity* (Penguin), Shafak brings Flaubert's inner world to life through a first-person narrative, portraying a man deeply attuned to the suffering of the dispossessed. Alongside it unfolds a third-person narrative in which 30 women, including his mother, his nursemaid, a circus star, an Egyptian dancer, the corpse of a prostitute he once saw and, of course, his most iconic heroine, Emma, reclaim the space to tell their stories.

Together, these narratives question who gets to tell a story and whose story endures against the vagaries of power and time. They also reveal why storytelling transcends the boundaries of race, ethnicity and gender. Edited excerpts from a conversation with Shafak:

Question: *Did this book grow from your anger and despair with everything that's going on in the world?*
Answer: I felt very overwhelmed by all that's happening. In a time of war, violence, division, technological uncertainty, and climate crisis, I found myself in a small room, looking for the perfect synonym. It led me to the question: what does literature mean when the world feels like it's breaking apart? And I was taken straight to the 19th century. I think it is not over yet. In many ways, we are still dealing with the consequences of that era. Our current time of immense turbulence, revolution, counter-revolution, empires coming to an end, nation-states, nationalism, and brother killing brother seems to stem from what began in the 19th century.

Q: *What led you to Gustave Flaubert and his* Madame Bovary*?*
A: When I revisited Flaubert's letters to his family, friends, and lover, I saw a delicate, honest artist struggling like all of us today. When I read *Madame Bovary*, I didn't like her, but after reading the letters, I realised Flaubert changed how we write novels and develop characters. He is regarded as a connoisseur of the female mind, and I could see that Emma, like us, yearns for something more, even though she doesn't know what it is.

A reader doesn't need to know much about Flaubert, or have read *Madame Bovary*, to enter the world I write about in my novel. That is because, for me, at its core, this book is about a lonely boy who was very imaginative, inventive, creative and yet very much misunderstood and seen as an oddball by Flaubert's father and brother, who were France's most respected doctors.



Only stories helped him see that other worlds exist. He had no way of knowing whether what he wrote would mean anything to anyone in history. On top of that, he had epilepsy, which made him read like a long list of embarrassments. How ironic that, in his esteemed family where everyone was successful and he was the failure, he's the only one we remember today, 200 years later.

Q: *Is that why writing Flaubert's fictional biography felt particularly relevant to you?*
A: I've always felt this feeling of otherness. I was born in France. My parents got separated. I came to Turkey with my mother to live with my maternal grandmother, who was loving and kind and left a big impact on me. At the same time, I was in a patriarchal neighbourhood and never felt that I fit in.

Since we migrated when I was very small and I grew up without seeing my father, it took me years to process his complete lack of interest in me, even though he had been a good father to my half-brothers. I never understood then why I was the 'forgotten' child. As I wrote the book, I found many emotional echoes of that in Flaubert's life.

He keeps writing in the midst of a siege, starvation, civil war, people literally eating the animals in the zoo. I wanted to dedicate this book to anyone who, for whatever reason, might have felt pushed to the periphery. I wanted to say, "You're my brother or sister."

Q: *And both of you ended up in court over your respective books...*
A: I was put on trial in Turkey for writing a novel called *The Bastard of Istanbul* (2006), which talks about the Armenian genocide, a big taboo topic in Turkey. I was accused of insulting "Turkishness". The prosecutor sought three years in prison. I found it all a bit Kafkaesque because the prosecutor used fictional characters' words from the book as evidence in court. It was also unnerving because there were ultranationalists on the streets who were accusing me of betrayal, burning my photos and spitting at them, and burning the EU flag. After all, they thought I was a pawn of Western powers.

Then, I was acquitted, but I still needed a bodyguard. I found that hard to digest. I'm not an important person or a politician, I'm just a writer.

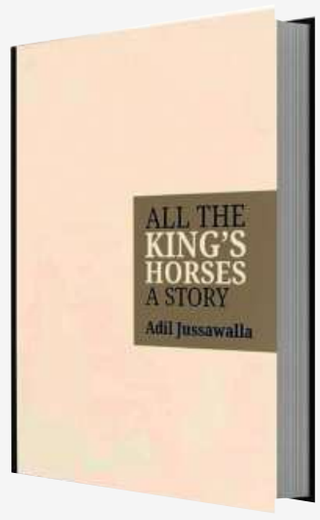
Years later, the prosecutor's office investigated two other books of mine, *The Gaze* and *10 Minutes 38 Seconds in This Strange World*, for "the crime of obscenity", which, coincidentally, is what Flaubert was also charged with for writing *Madame Bovary*. As a Turkish novelist, whatever you touch with your pen, from history to politics to sexuality to gender, you can easily get into trouble, be sued, investigated, or even exiled for your words.

The interviewer is an independent journalist with bylines in Indian and international publications.

The shape of longing

In a book of memos between husband and wife, poet Adil Jussawalla makes repair a form of remembrance

Sumana Roy



All the King's Horses: A Story
Adil Jussawalla
Poetrywala
₹200

I am reading Adil Jussawalla's *All the King's Horses: A Story* a few months after his 86th birthday. The last book I read by Jussawalla was *Soliloquies* (2025), a verse drama he wrote at 18. The sense of two – duologue, dialogic, a divided self – is the DNA of this new book, the reason it must have reminded me of *Soliloquies*: two creative selves, two Jussawallas, the oldest books and the youngest.

Jussawalla remakes a children's rhyme into his title and epigraph: *All the king's horses and all the king's men/ Helped put what broke together again*. The original nursery rhyme, *All the king's horses and all the king's men/ Couldn't put Humpty together again*, is the fragmented modern, what T.S. Eliot characterised as the "dissociation of sensibility". A hundred years after Eliot's essay 'The Metaphysical Poets', Jussawalla is putting what "broke together again".

It is possible that the structure of *All the King's Horses* has pushed my thoughts into this syntax of bookends – the poems are arranged in sections titled 'Memos of a Wife to a Husband' and 'Memos of a Husband to a Wife', with an 'In Between'. I find myself thinking of Anglo-Saxon literature, 'The Wife's Lament' and 'The Husband's Message'. Jussawalla's word for 'lament' and 'message' is 'memo'. The temper of the Anglo-Saxon poems derives from *viraha*, a forced separation from the beloved. Take these lines from 'The Wife's Lament':

Friends live on earth
lying in bed with their beloveds
while I in the time before dawn
alone walk
under oak tree.

These are from Jussawalla's poem 'There *Is* A Gap' in 'Memos of a Wife to a Husband':

I vow not to see you, bleed instead
this amber from a bitter tree, you
caught in each gumdrop like a fly.

The wife's separation from the husband; the tree, an oak from a millennia ago, a 'bitter tree' in this 21st century. The Anglo-Saxon poem ends with: *Too often he remembers a house full of joy*; Jussawalla's with music: *Remember the sound of our first doorbell... Stockhausen, Berg, Janis Joplin... The music you wanted was here*.

Ancestry of emotions

'The Husband's Message', read as a companion poem, has its parallel in the Indian poet's 'Memos of a Husband to a Wife'. The Anglo-Saxon poem opens with waking: *Now I wish to tell/ apart from you –/ the kindred of trees/ I wake from seeds/ Within me*. Jussawalla's opens with sleep, as if in response: *Sleeping against you, wary of times...* Plant life sprouts in both the openings: the seeds and trees in the anonymous poem, "a time of green meadows" ('Selves') in Jussawalla's.

The Humpty Dumpty epigraph and the Anglo-Saxon elegies are just two among several things that Jussawalla is remaking. Remaking is reclaiming. The word 'left' recurs through the collection, as if it were a kind of timekeeping: *I'm here/ but by then you'd left. You have not left* – a four-line poem ends like this, four monosyllabic words, as if unable to recover from the shock of leaving. The 'you' is the dedicatee in the book – Veronik, Jussawalla's wife – these poems for her a balancing of the equation between life and death. This remaking – rearranging – is a kind of staving off, a gentle deferral of what has come to be.

The Indian poet's alignment with the oldest poems in the English language, with elegies about married love from more than a millennia ago, is a groping for an ancestry of emotions that keeps us human, that are repeated without our active participation: *Whoever cares to repeat this/ as a children's story now,/ say it began with smiles,/ then rupture* ('Shark').

In this slim book of poems that Jussawalla's health prevented from becoming a 'long story', we meet *yesterday's hive of hands* and *distillations of earlier days* and the awareness, from *Solaris*, that *the time for cruel miracles was not past*. The past is a fruit being cut open.

There is *a gap, though sweet and*
tender juice
riots around the knife, the sharp ends of
the circle
don't meet round the fruit.
(– 'There *Is* A Gap')

Two images have stayed with me – the ends of the circle not being able to meet around the fruit; and *the two of us, unable to speak, still lovers*. They are as old as love and poetry and death; and their fruit.

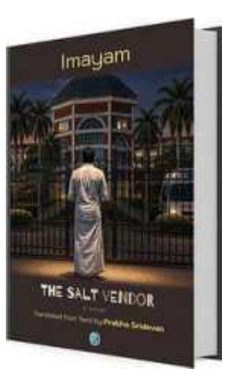
The reviewer is a poet, author, and literary critic.

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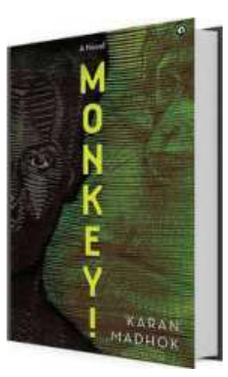


BROWSER

The Salt Vendor
Imayam, trs Prabha Sridevan
Ratna Books
₹599
The Sahitya Akademi Award-winning writer's new novel is set during the harrowing days of the COVID-19 pandemic. Imayam's wry humour and sardonic take on the state machinery shine through in this story centred on a hapless man named Governor.



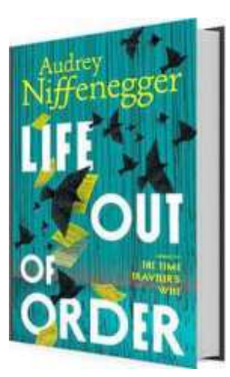
Monkey!
Karan Madhok
Aleph
₹499
Moving between a hotel in the mountains and a seemingly endless train journey, this surrealistic novel explores human frailty in the face of nature's overwhelming power. Madhok says the book is inspired by his lifelong fascination with the Himalaya.



Partita
Barbara Kingsolver
Faber & Faber
₹799
The Pulitzer-winning author of *Demon Copperhead* returns with a story of music and passion set in rural America. Kingsolver's classical piano training enriches her vivid descriptions, while her knack for inhabiting her characters brings the story to life.



Life Out of Order
Audrey Niffenegger
Jonathan Cape
₹999
In this much-anticipated sequel to *The Time Traveller's Wife*, we return to the time-travelling daughter in a near-dystopian setting that moves from riot-torn Chicago streets to a Museum of Lost Souls and a flooded future London. There are other time travellers here too.



Understanding an elusive big cat

Kulbhushansingh Suryawanshi explores what it means to share a landscape with the snow leopard



A snow leopard in the Himalaya. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

Janaki Lenin

Peter Matthiessen's mystical *The Snow Leopard* (1978) casts a long shadow over any writing on the enigmatic cat. Since then, a spate of popular books on it have been published in the west, with western researchers and travellers taking centre stage. Here at last is *The Ghost of the Mountains* by Kulbhushansingh Suryawanshi, an Indian researcher. It's the story of a lad growing up in Aurangabad in central India who dared to dream of scaling mountains like the legendary mountaineer Reinhold Messner and studying wildlife like the field biologist George Schaller. He achieved those ambitions against the odds.

Studying prey habits

How does one study a creature that is rarely seen? It's not for nothing that the snow leopard is called 'the ghost of the mountains'. If you claim to have seen a yeti, you could get away with it, Suryawanshi says, but you face ridicule if you state that you have seen a snow leopard. As a Master's student, he sidesteps the quandary by studying the grazing habits of its prey, the blue sheep, which is really a goat in sheep's clothing. He studies the ghost itself for his PhD, negotiating the dangerous terrain while keeping his senses alert, and is rewarded with the sight of the beautiful elusive cats playing, courting, and hunting.

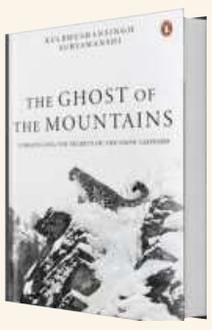
How to reduce the impact of humans on snow leopards is a central theme of the book. Even if the cats are no more than apparitions to most people, signs of their presence are around. When they kill livestock, herders retaliate. Yet livestock degrade pastures by reducing the forage available for wild herbivores such as the blue sheep. Studying snow leopard droppings, the author and his team establish that given a choice, the cat prefers its prey wild. Would encouraging herding practices that leave enough forage for wild herbivores increase snow leopard numbers? Then, even while worrying about antagonising older researchers, Suryawanshi asks: would more snow leopards mean they would kill more livestock? This thought process is uncommon because the mainstream discourse on tiger conservation is consumed by increasing the numbers of tigers. What are the consequences of having more predators is rarely asked. This isn't the only time he challenges accepted wisdom. Later he questions whether large cats are indeed the top dogs of their habitats.

Saviour complex

In India, conservation suffers from a conservationist saviour complex. Conservation NGOs decide which mitigation measure to use, where to set it up, and how. Villagers are passive recipients of charity. Building cat-proof corrals and offering monetary compensation to lessen the burden of living with predators is widely practiced. Suryawanshi learns that autonomy encourages farmers and herders to become active partners in protecting their property. He also realises that money can't buy tolerance. Women nurture their animals, often staying awake night after night to keep watch, yet men pocket the cash when snow leopards kill livestock. The emotional loss women suffer most often goes unacknowledged.

In the larger scheme, the problems of livestock grazing and snow leopard bashing are of a lesser magnitude than those posed by solar parks destroying the best Spitian grasslands. In tackling powerful corporations, Suryawanshi continues to see communities as the custodians of the mountains.

While communities can thwart the best-made plans of companies, the author seems befuddled when a bitter rift cleaves the global community of snow leopard researchers. In 2017, a team of western experts downgraded the IUCN Red List status of the snow leopard from 'endangered' to 'vulnerable' without the participation of any researcher from a snow leopard range country. This is yet another reminder of the predominance of western narratives of the snow leopard.



The Ghost of the Mountains
Kulbhushansingh Suryawanshi
Penguin Allen Lane
₹999

In the author's lively recounting, research findings and conservation efforts are neither dense nor dry. Through vivid descriptions, we see the azure blue skies, breathe the oxygen-poor air, labour up treacherous mountain slopes, and revel at the magnificence of a certain spotted cat with a furry boa of a tail and snowshoe paws. The sprinkling of lyrical sentences makes the book a joy to read. For instance, when a fox unexpectedly comes upon a cavorting snow leopard couple, he describes its blood-curdling scream "as if [he] had already died and was looking down on his own dead body."

Reminiscent of Jonathan Slaght's book, *Owls of the Eastern Ice*, set in the frigid expanses of the Russian Far East, this is the memoir of an intrepid and committed Indian wildlife researcher and conservationist. For long, the alpine ghost was the soul of wilderness in public imagination. But in Suryawanshi's telling, the snow leopard lives cheek by jowl with humans, even if they rarely ever see it. In doing so, he breaks free of the mystical aura conjured by Matthiessen and casts a long sunbeam not only on this most enigmatic cat but what it means to live with it.

The reviewer, who writes on wildlife and conservation, is the co-author of Snakes, Drugs and Rock 'n' Roll.



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INTERVIEW

FROM CARE TO COMMERCE

Public policy expert Ameer Shahul on how financial interests and claim rejections are driving up the cost of treatment

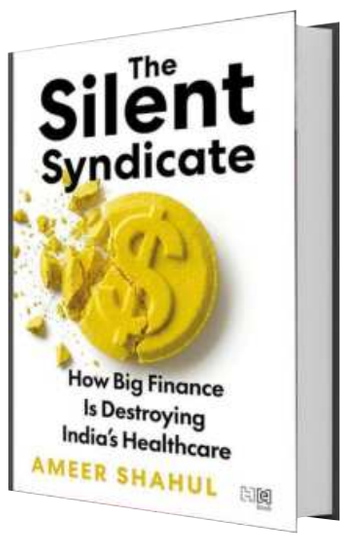
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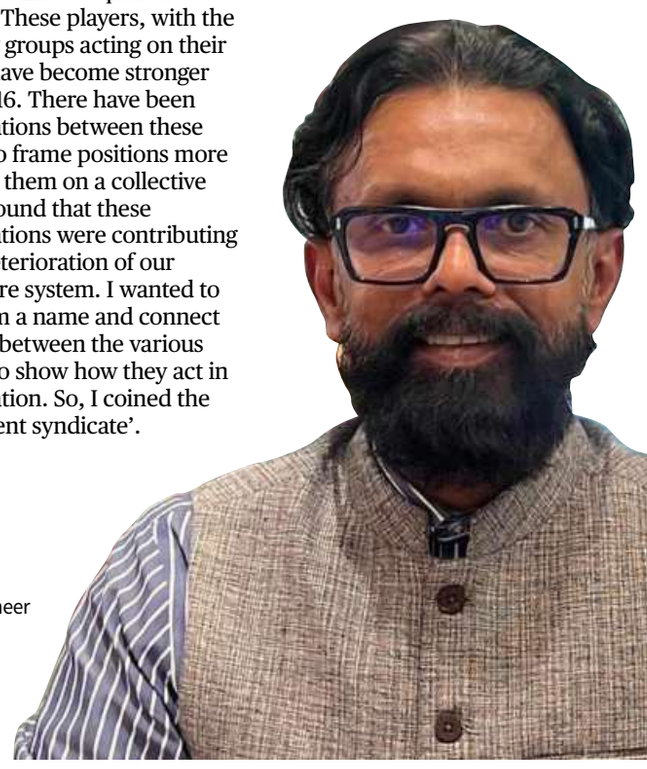
In a country where the bulk of medical expenses for most people are out of pocket, high healthcare costs are no less dangerous than any deadly disease. In his new book, *The Silent Syndicate: How Big Finance is Destroying India's Healthcare* (Hachette India), public policy expert Ameer Shahul documents the infiltration of global financial interests into India's healthcare sector and how it is making medical care even more unaffordable and inaccessible for the average citizen. Excerpts from an interview:

Question: *What does 'silent syndicate' mean?*
Answer: While working on the book, I came across quite a few healthcare players, ranging from actors in the pharma industry to finance, diagnostics, insurance, and a plethora of lobbyists, who have been active in the Indian space for almost a quarter century. These players, with the lobbying groups acting on their behalf, have become stronger since 2016. There have been conversations between these groups to frame positions more suited to them on a collective basis. I found that these conversations were contributing to the deterioration of our healthcare system. I wanted to give them a name and connect the dots between the various players to show how they act in coordination. So, I coined the term 'silent syndicate'.

Q: *The fuel on which this 'syndicate' runs is global financial capital. How does the entry of private equity alter the nature of a hospital?*
A: Once a private equity firm picks up a stake in a hospital, they put a member on the hospital's board, or sometimes take over the board, depending on the percentage of stake they have. Then they start introducing their metrics. For instance, we used to talk about the average number of days before a patient can get out of the hospital, the re-hospitalisation that happens after the preliminary recuperation, and the number of OPD visits by a patient.

Those were the metrics used by doctors and hospitals for a long period. But once private equity players came into the fold, they changed the metrics to occupancy rate, average revenue per bed, EBITDA (Earnings Before Interest, Taxes, Depreciation, and Amortisation), quarterly revenue, and return on capital employed. And they started expecting hospitals to perform to the tune of those metrics.





Author Ameer Shahul

Q: *But weren't these metrics already in place, given that hospitals in the private sector had to function as profitable businesses?*
A: About 30-40 years ago, hospitals were not considered an industry. Their primary role was that of care centres. But over time, their role morphed into that of a profitable business. That's when these other metrics started to come in. They started looking at how much revenue each doctor is bringing to the hospital and fixing internal targets for doctors, which was never the case earlier. Doctors always used to be assessed in terms of the number of patients handled at the OPD, the number of room visits, the number of ICU visits, etc. Under the new paradigm, what mattered was average revenue per doctor, and conversion rates – OPD patients to inpatient cases, inpatient to surgeries, inpatients to ICU patients. These conversions are counted today for each doctor. So, if you're a doctor who is not performing to the satisfaction of the management – say, you were supposed to bring in ₹20 lakh a month and you are only able to bring in ₹10 lakh – you will be shown the door. Somebody who brings in ₹50 lakh against a target of ₹15 lakh will be rewarded.

Doctors and the hospital management are under pressure to bring in more revenue, so they obviously have to pass this on to the patients. The consultation fee charged by each doctor is looked at by the management and revised every quarter. So are the procedure charges. Even a drip line, a saline administered to a patient in an emergency, is a unit from which revenue needs to be generated. Sometimes, this goes up 10 or 20 times its actual cost. The business of care has changed into a business of profit.

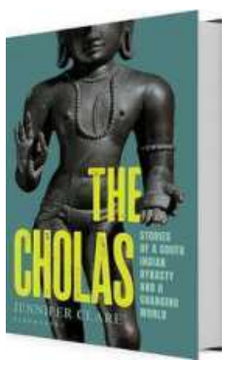
Q: *Your book suggests that it's when you need health cover the most that there is a good chance you won't get it. Why is that?*
A: If you look at the IRDAI (Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India) numbers, it's clear that in 2024-25, claims worth about ₹30,000 crore were rejected or repudiated.

Q: *Given such a huge claims rejection figure, how come health insurance firms boast settlement ratios of 96% to 98%?*
A: This percentage has nothing to do with the total value of the rejections. When they say they have a 98% claim settlement ratio, that only means that out of 100 claims received, they have honoured 98. But you're not looking at what those 2% of rejected claims are. Suppose you have a small injury – say, a broken finger – and you go to a hospital and the bill is ₹5,000. You submit it, and the insurer will be happy to settle the claim. But suppose you face a serious situation – say, a cardiac issue – where you need ₹50 lakh. Imagine you have a coverage of ₹1 crore and are eligible for ₹50 lakh. You won't get it. Most of the claims getting rejected are large claims, which the insurance companies don't want to honour, because those are the kinds of claims that will hurt them the most.

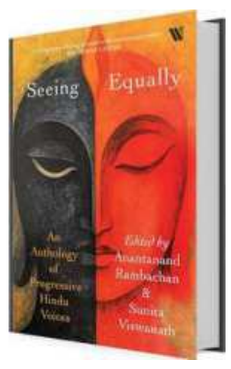
Read the full interview online.

Scan the QR code to watch Ameer Shahul in conversation.

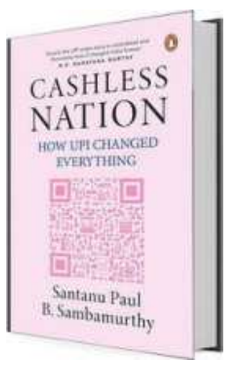
The Cholas
Jennifer Clare
Bloomsbury
₹799
Clare traces the rise and fall of the Chola dynasty, exploring its influence on south Indian politics, religion, art, agriculture, and trade. She draws on inscriptions, literature and architecture to reveal the achievements and contradictions of the empire.



Seeing Equally
Anantanand Rambachan, Sunita Viswanath
Westland Books
₹599
This anthology brings together Hindu voices to explore a theology rooted in equality, dignity, and social justice. It presents a vision of Hinduism centred on liberation, inclusion, and the equal worth of all human beings.



Cashless Nation
Santanu Paul, B. Sambamurthy
Penguin
₹899
This explores the people, partnerships, and innovations behind India's digital payments revolution. It examines how India built a payments network that transformed financial inclusion, and connected businesses and consumers.



From Muddle Age to Middle Age to Me
Indu Balachandran
Rupa Publications India
₹395
Balachandran explores midlife as a time for self-love, reinvention, and freedom, encouraging women over 40 to embrace ageing with humour and confidence. The book covers everything from health and relationships to spirituality.







(Clockwise from below) Jayasri Burman; *Wings & Tales*; models wear designs from *Devi: The Eternal Muse*; Burman's *Shankharupa*; Rahul Mishra; Svabhu Kohli; and Vikram Goyal. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Myths for modern worldviews

The broad consensus is that Bollywood, despite regularly turning to mythology for inspiration, still has a long way to go when it comes to handling the rich terrain of lores. Director Om Raut's *Adipurush* (2023) was criticised for perpetuating a revisionist take on the *Ramayana*, though, oddly, nearly everyone across the political spectrum panned it for its plastic animation and strange dialogues. Namit Malhotra's *Ramayana* (2026), the most expensive Indian film to date, starring Ranbir Kapoor as Rama and Yash as Ravana and set to hit theatres on November 5, will likely face the same scrutiny.

Beyond celluloid, however, the interpretations are subtler, more personal. Designers and contemporary artists choose specific elements to illustrate their worldview, instead of faithfully reproducing the myths and epics (as traditional artists and weavers have been wont to do).

If you look at the *Mahabharata*, its theme of ego can be transferred to contemporary times — in the way we approach nature. It's the same story of pettiness. We are making the same mistakes. Everybody grows; I am a different Jayasri from the one I was 10 years ago. But as a society we are not growing, and it's high time we do

JAYASRI BURMAN
Artist

GODS ARE BACK IN FASHION









each other. Yesterday, the painter and sculptor unveiled two interconnected expressions: *Mukti*, an exhibition of paintings, and *Amlaan*, her debut in the world of jewellery. The characters in both are women from Hindu epics (such as Sita from the *Ramayana* and Draupadi from the *Mahabharata*), myths, Bengali literature, and local folklore, such as the forest guardian Bonbibi.

"In the Sunderbans, people believe that they will be protected from tigers if they pray to Bonbibi. So, she's worshipped by Hindus and Muslims alike," says Burman. "It is not about the woman, it is about what she represents: the idea of unifying across gender, caste and religious lines."

Her jewellery collection, which she has been developing for nearly a decade in collaboration with artisans, features imagery and symbolism from her paintings and sculptures. They draw on her childhood memories of Bengal, stories of Radha and Krishna, Durga and Shakti – all picked out in gold and gemstones.

The past is alive

Creatives are rarely chained to their inspirations. In their nimble hands, a sacred tree becomes a ballooning wildflower with limbs; the figure of goddess Kali becomes a transformative force. A few months ago, fashion designer Rahul Mishra took this powerful storytelling international.

For his Autumn/Winter collection 'Devi: The Eternal Muse', he drew on architecture and sculpture from ancient caves and temples such as Ajanta Caves in Maharashtra and the Chennakeshava Temple in Karnataka, translating them into the language of couture for his July showcase in Paris.

"The collection emerged from a bit of frustration about how people don't understand India," he says. "For the foreign eye, India is still just the Taj Mahal, slums and chicken *tikka*." So, his clothes stripped away the stereotypes. He used hand embroidery to trace the contours of sandstone, basalt, soapstone and bronze sculpture. *Zardozi* and *dabka* were combined with stones, crystals and bugle beads to create trompe-l'œil surfaces that look carved rather than stitched. Mishra also collaborated with clay artisan Sumant Kumar to create bespoke ceremonial headpieces inspired by the crowns on temple sculptures.

Mishra is not a revivalist; he has always looked at his job as "part-historian, part-designer", and with collections such as *Devi*, his goal is to show the world that our epics, our past, must also be appreciated for the radical interventions in art, architecture and design.

In many ways, both politicians and artists follow a similar approach to India's past: excavating it for stories and hints that reaffirm their agendas. The difference is that in the creatives' hands, the past is alive. It adapts to the realities and concerns of our time, giving a voice to those that are pushed to the margins, that the majoritarian forces ignore. And that could come as a Garuda flying on Goyal's chair, a dark-skinned woman giving it her all on Burman's canvas, a beautiful Luna moth in Kohli's world, or a towering goddess walking the runway.



The writer is a journalist and educator.

A hybrid imagination

Goa-based artist Svabhu Kohli, who recently collaborated with French luxury house Hermès on the visual merchandising for its Mumbai store, focuses on the myths and folklore of communities inhabiting the country's forests, wetlands, and riverine systems. But Kohli gives them their own hybrid narrative. In their hands, a moth from the forests of Goa becomes a half-bird, half-flower thing of beauty. "All of these stories [India's epics and myths] are about meaning-making," they say. "As a queer and introverted child, I built my own universe. So these stories created meaning. They were ways of coming together, a refuge in our dark lives."

Their approach was beautifully illustrated in a recent project that synthesised two worlds: theirs and that of Ram Sangchoju, a 13-year-old disabled boy living in Pakke Tiger Reserve in Arunachal Pradesh, whom he was introduced to three years ago. Sangchoju watches the forest from his window because he cannot step into it, and dreams up his own mythologies: "how the hornbill fell in love with the fish, and how the fish fell in love with the trees".

When the Lodhi Art Festival invited the artist to paint a wall in Delhi for the annual street art event this February, Kohli created it jointly with Sangchoju, blending the boy's cosmologies with their own. Luna and atlas moths from the Western Ghats shared the wall with Sangchoju's snakes, with the cosmos for scales. "The forest lives within you. How can you protect something if you are not in love with it?" they ask.



GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Tanushree Ghosh
tanushree.ghosh@thehindu.co.in

When the Dharamshala International Film Festival (DIFF) started in 2012, there were no cinema halls in McLeod Ganj. Films were shown on DVDs. Filmmaker couple-collaborators Ritu Sarin and Tenzing Sonam brought their experience of the hospitality of small towns overseas hosting film festivals to the Dalai Lama's backyard. Fourteen editions later, DIFF, held in Tibetan Children's Village in Upper Dharamshala, has grown. From around 2,000 attendees in its inaugural edition to over 15,000 in 2025.

While Hansal Mehta's career-pivoting directorial *Shahid* (2012), starring Rajkummar Rao, opened the first edition, a black-and-white Punjabi drama, *Birds in the Dark/ Hanere De Panchi*, produced by Mehta, will close the 15th edition today. The film recently won the prestigious New Currents Award and Songwon Vision Audience Award (Asia) at the Busan International Film Festival (BIFF). BIFF co-juror and *Village Rockstars* director Rima Das's new Assamese film, *Not A Hero* [Crystal Bear Special Mention, Berlinale], opened DIFF 2026.

The four-day festival is showing 95 films from 40 countries. "Most of the films this year could inspire a spark. The boundaries for telling stories are so non-existent today, from the short form to the long form, from slow to crazily paced, from fiction to non-fiction," says director of programming, Bina Paul, adding that the only challenge she faces is organising premiere shows "since producers are attracted by competitions". DIFF is one of the few Indian festivals to not have competitive segments. Paul brings to DIFF her nearly two decades of experience as former artistic director of the International Film Festival of Kerala (IFFK). Excerpts from an interview with Sarin and Paul:

IN CONVERSATION

ALL WE IMAGINE AS INDIE

Ritu Sarin and Bina Paul on building a global non-mainstream cinema culture in the Himalayan town as Dharamshala International Film Festival turns 15



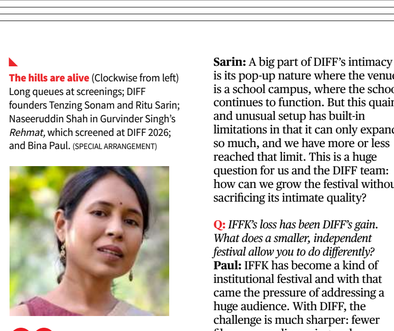


Incidentally, Saim Sadiq's *Joyland*, Pakistan's 2023 Oscar entry, whose release was briefly banned in Pakistan, and it was rejected by IFFK Kerala in 2022, was screened to packed halls at DIFF that year, with mattresses laid out to accommodate the overflow.

Q: *Did you imagine DIFF would grow into a festival drawing filmmakers and audiences from across the globe?*
Sarin: We just wanted to create a space for our local audiences to watch the kinds of films that we loved – non-mainstream, independent films – which were not easy to access. And we thought, let's ask filmmakers to come in person so that there would be an opportunity for interaction and discussion. From our own experience at various film festivals, the ones that made the biggest impact were the more intimate ones where directors and audiences could easily meet. We tried to replicate that model at DIFF.

Any motif, even religious, is raw material or resource in the hands of an artist. It is a piece of information. Why should I be limited in how I use it or whether I use it at all? The Taj Mahal can symbolise love as much as it can represent dedication and history. We can use the same works in different ways

RAHUL KUMAR
Art curator and practising ceramic artist



The hills are alive (Clockwise from left) Long queues at screenings; DIFF founders Tenzing Sonam and Ritu Sarin; Naseeruddin Shah in Gurvinder Singh's *Rehmat*, which screened at DIFF 2026; and Bina Paul. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

I love DIFF and the way it has grown over the years, so consistently and patiently, bringing some of the best films and creating a space for cinephiles and filmmakers to come together and have conversations freely. It's a place that gives you hope and makes you feel at home. Sharing films, food, the beauty of the mountains, and the richness of the local culture makes it so special. It feels wonderful to have our film *Not a Hero* open this year's festival.

RIMA DAS
Filmmaker

The way DIFF just grew from year to year, taking on a life and a momentum of its own was truly unexpected. But its growing success didn't translate into more funding opportunities and this obstacle has plagued us year after year. Also, given the nature of McLeod Ganj, where DIFF is held – a crowded tourist town in the mountains with no cinemas, and with very little space to expand, the logistics of running the festival has exponentially mounted. There is only so much more the festival can expand, and we really worry about how to manage the increased expectations and exploding numbers of visitors who want to attend.

Q: *How do you protect the intimacy of a small festival as its reputation grows?*
Sarin: A big part of DIFF's intimacy is its pop-up nature where the venue is a school campus, where the school continues to function. But this quaint and unusual setup has built-in limitations in that it can only expand so much, and we have more or less reached that limit. This is a huge question for us and the DIFF team: how can we grow the festival without sacrificing its intimate quality?

Q: *IFFK's loss has been DIFF's gain. What does a smaller, independent festival allow you to do differently?*
Paul: IFFK has become a kind of institutional festival and with that came the pressure of addressing a huge audience. With DIFF, the challenge is much sharper: fewer films, a very discerning and committed audience and a very clear vision. Leading a programming team to fulfil that vision is a task. As a person who has always believed that it is the small, perhaps, unheard film that is the gem, this offers me the space to explore.

DIFF was a well-established festival when I joined the team a few years ago. The emphasis on independent cinema already existed. What I do is try and strengthen this angle and bring a more pan-regional spectrum, whether Indian or from around the world.

Q: *How do you define independent cinema in 2026?*
Paul: Today, the definition is undergoing a relook. Most films are made in a kind of hybrid manner when one looks at the economics of it, whether through country co-productions, crowdfunding, small investments, etc. DIFF looks for independent films that come from marginalised identities, fringe politics, regional realities, caste dynamics, urban alienation, rather than with sugarcoated storytelling. Filmmakers dealing with such content tend to carve out finance and keep their creative freedom.

Q: *What emerging trends did you observe in DIFF's domestic submissions this year?*
Paul: While traditionally, the south of the country has always had its share of independent cinematic voices, we see this happening a lot in the Punjab, Haryana and North Indian belt. Certainly, this delving into one's own history and culture is unravelling a unique, deeply sensitive storytelling.

Q: *Which film best represents where independent cinema is headed?*
Paul: Perhaps, a film like *The Calf Doll* [by Ankur Hooda]. I'm not commenting on the merits of the film but rather on what it represents. A local story, local actors, very much on the cusp of fiction and documentary. It's quite an interesting mix of aesthetics, veiled social analysis and an atmosphere that seems familiar to the filmmaker. The film is steeped in animals, seasons, rituals, omens, which seem to come from a lived experience. For a first-time filmmaker, the film embodies the direction we are seeing in many films being made in India. Also, the film is produced and supported by another local filmmaker, Achal Mishra. That's a new trend in Indian cinema, where filmmakers are supporting each other.

Q: *What is the responsibility of a film festival when a film becomes politically uncomfortable? In DIFF's 2024 edition, two Palestinian films were dropped after the festival began [*From Ground Zero; *and* No Other Land, *which later won the 2025 Oscars for Best Documentary Feature].*
Sarin: All film festivals in India must obtain clearance from the I&B Ministry for every film they wish to screen. At DIFF, our policy is to find and select the best contemporary independent films we can. We try not to let political considerations shape our choices, but we recognise that some subjects are harder to clear than others. This was the case with the two Palestinian films: we didn't receive clearance for them and had to withdraw them from the programme. It is a difficult dilemma, and one that every film festival in India has to navigate.





Sense and repetition Will Georgia Oakley's self-assured and thoroughly modern film join the ranks of great Jane Austen screen adaptations?

BINGE WATCH

The Austen trap

What makes a new *Sense and Sensibility* worth telling?

That is bewitching, the idea of one's happiness depending entirely on another person. It is not always possible," says the pragmatic and introverted Elinor (Daisy Edgar-Jones) to her impulsive sister, Marianne.

These lines from the new *Sense and Sensibility* film, directed by Georgia Oakley, are indicative of the moral dilemma at the heart of not just this story, but Austen's body of work as a whole. Based on the Jane Austen classic of the same name, the story follows the Dashwood sisters, their contrasting responses to their father's death, and their subsequent search for suitable husbands.

Adapt well

Oakley's version of *Sense and Sensibility* is under great pressure because the previous large-screen adaptation of the novel, Ang Lee's 1995 film, starring and written by Emma Thompson (and which won the Oscar for Best Adapted Screenplay), is widely regarded as perhaps the greatest Austen adaptation of all time.

Alongside the six-part TV series *Pride and Prejudice* (1995), where Colin Firth played a memorable Mr. Darcy, Ang Lee's *Sense and Sensibility* is widely credited for the Austen-mania that gripped Hollywood in the mid-to-late 1990s. Will Oakley's self-assured and thoroughly modern adaptation join their ranks?

So, what qualities work for a really good Austen adaptation? Let me put the screenplay as the all-important foundation. Thompson's screenplay for Lee's film married quicksilver, super-witty repartee with Austen's softer, more blatantly sentimental side. The key was to make sure Austen's critiques of society travelled to the screen in a non-preachy way. Exposition has far less latitude onscreen than it does on the page – Thompson's genius was in recognising this and making the necessary adjustments. In this context, a word also for Rajiv Menon's excellent Tamil adaptation *Kandukondain Kandukondain* (2000), featuring an ensemble cast led by Mammootty, Aishwarya Rai, Abbas, Ajith and Tabu, with its screenplay written by Menon and dialogues by the noted Tamil novelist Sujatha.

Let your hair down

Another important factor in modernising the settings of an Austen novel is to ensure the world you create stands on its own terms, not just as a super-faint, superficial echo of the English society Austen lived through. In other words, if you're letting your hair down, go all the way with it, no half-measures. Two of my favourite Austen adaptations underscore this point – the 1995 Alicia Silverstone-starrer *Clueless* and the Bollywood film *Aisha* (2010).

Both are modernised adaptations of Austen's great comedy-of-manners, *Emma*, about a happily shallow, meddlesome protagonist who vastly overestimates her own matchmaking talents. *Clueless* worked because of the irresistible, all-too-familiar world of American high-school hi-jinks it created, with Silverstone's character, Cher Horowitz, playing the queen bee to perfection. Similarly, the upper-class Delhi milieu of *Aisha* is a wonderful, incorrigibly mercantile and status-conscious setting, rich in intrigue and consumerist excess.

Pass the pitfalls

One stratagem that absolutely does not work with Austen is the metafictional, self-referential dialogue that has infected so much of contemporary streaming. While Austen had a lot of stylistic traits considered "modern" for her era, self-referential logic-loops were not one of them. The Dakota Johnson-starrer *Persuasion* (2022) nevertheless broke the fourth wall relentlessly, talking to the audience *ad nauseam*, like *Fleabag* on steroids with none of the charm or wit of the Phoebe Waller-Bridge series.

Another very common pitfall is the tendency to "flatten" Austen's complex views on romance into the beats of a typical Hollywood romcom. Gwyneth Paltrow's *Emma* (1996) is a typical example of this, as is the 2007 film *Mansfield Park*, which utterly wasted the considerable talents of its leading lady (Billie Piper) precisely this way.

A side-effect of this phenomenon is also observed in casting – in *Sense and Sensibility*, Austen specifically introduces the character of Edward Ferrars as an awkward, not-handsome man who does not possess the charm of, say, a Darcy. And yet, even Oakley couldn't resist the temptation to cast George MacKay, who's bursting with Hollywood-good-looks and a weapons-grade jawline for the ages.

Don't get me wrong. I am genuinely delighted to see another Austen film on the large screen. It's a nice, much-needed change of pace from the relentless waves of comic-book and video-game adaptations dominating Hollywood these days. I just wish that Oakley and her cast had avoided the missteps outlined above – and had added their own distinctive flourishes to a classic text.



Aditya Mani Jha is working on his first book of non-fiction.



PERSON OF INTEREST

HECHIN HAOKIP: PEOPLE FIRST

The social worker on helping communities heal in a displaced and divided Manipur

Hechin Haokip, 47, says the world turned upside down three years ago. That's when an underlying divide between Manipur's majority Meitei community and its tribal Kuki-Zo people cracked open almost overnight, creating a deadly crevasse that has displaced thousands and segregated the State. "A lot of people I have worked with for 10-15 years, who spoke the same language when we talked about discrimination or human rights violations by the State, began talking so differently after the conflict broke out," she says. "Now it seems like human rights have become community rights."

Two months before the violence began, Haokip, the founder of a 20-year-old community organisation called Centre for Women and Girls (CWG), was at an NGO conference in Bangkok. CWG works with different ethnic communities in the hill districts of Chandel and Tengnoupal on issues of gender equity, child rights, peace processes and livelihoods. In Bangkok, people kept asking her where she was from and then telling her she didn't look Indian. "I am from a very small State called Manipur," she would say.

Back home, she is now reminded that she doesn't look Meitei. "My Manipur has become tinier and tinier," she says.

Leaving home, twice

Haokip's village of Molnoi, in Tengnoupal near the Indo-Myanmar border, is in the foothills of the Kuki-dominated hills. A national highway separates it from the Meitei-controlled valley. Four months after the conflict began, the village was attacked. Many had already fled, and that day Haokip too had to leave behind her home and her office.

She stayed away for almost three years, opting to move 20 km away to multi-ethnic Chandel, with a significant Naga population, so that CWG's hires could stay mixed. "That's how we are trying to avoid the communal landscape," she says.

After conflict broke out there too, she moved back to Molnoi in March. "It's a merry-go-round with no end," says Haokip. The new divisions limit where the Kuki members on their team can go. Some areas are now reachable only by Naga colleagues.

Some of CWG's own staff were caught in Imphal when the violence first broke out. They fled mob attacks, in one case throwing away office laptops as they ran. They returned traumatised.

That's when Haokip decided the team needed to help itself first. "How do we normalise or revive our daily routine?" That was the big question with no easy answers. They decided they needed to turn themselves into 'barefoot counsellors'. There was no easy access to mental health practitioners, and certainly nobody with conflict zone experience, so Haokip began writing to people. Feminist publisher Urvashi Butalia recommended Shobna Sonpar, who had worked in Kashmir. After multiple requests, Sonpar, now retired, agreed to come to Manipur for a week. "That was a big moment for us," says Haokip.

Hechin Haokip is the founder of Centre for Women and Girls that works with different ethnic communities in Manipur. (SHASHWAT MALIK)

Sonpar helped the team be better, more empathetic listeners, and give time to people without judgment. They began conducting freelisting interviews, developed by the WHO and UNHCR, in relief camps. People spoke to them of trauma, loss, their worries about their children's future, the lack of privacy/ hygiene and the shortage of life-saving cancer and blood-pressure medicines. "Some of the people in the camps are literally waiting for death," says Haokip.

Seeds and stories

"In our mental health approach, we combine talking about mental well-being with trying to reactivate normal life with small income-generating activities," adds Haokip. That could include making *chai* in a relief camp, starting a community thrift store or farming. "A lot of people are planting cabbage, onion, coriander leaves. The activity itself is therapeutic, and through it conversations start changing," she says. "People begin talking about harvest times, and types of seeds. They also report that after they worked in the fields, they are able to sleep better, eat better, and thus have more energy to go back to work."

Haokip and her colleagues want to normalise the discussions around mental health. "Here, people believe that a nightmare can mean a forest ghost is following you," she says, laughing.

The CWG team has prioritised its own care too. Thursdays post-lunch are dedicated to self-care – whether it's playing volleyball, hiking or making and eating the traditional Manipuri *singju* salad (a Meitei dish that everybody loves).

Leaders of today

Watching the protests against the voter roll revision play out in the capital from her now-quiet village, emptied of most children and seniors, walking past deserted households and unkempt homesteads where the grass grows unhindered, dependent on rations brought from the marketplace by Naga colleagues, Haokip feels optimistic about the youth. "At our youth cohort where we conduct workshops, a teenage boy asked us last year, 'Why do people call us future leaders? We are the leaders of today'," she recalls. "The protests proved him right."

For three years, Haokip didn't travel by air. Her Meitei friends don't come to her village. In July, she travelled to Imphal airport for the first time since the start of the conflict, escorted by security forces in an armoured Casspir MPV and masked up to be doubly cautious. But her thinking hasn't changed. "I still maintain the same ideas about how we should continue talking, bringing people together," she says.



Priya Ramani *is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.*

GOREN BRIDGE

Good bidding, maybe

East-West vulnerable, West deals

Bob Jones

South in today's deal was Chinese World Champion Jack Zhao, who has lived in Boca Raton, Florida, for many years.. The auction at the table is unknown to us, mainly because Zhao refuses to disclose it. We offer the possible auction above, where South's two-club cue bid created a game force. The reason for West's spade lead, rather than a high club, is also unknown to us, perhaps for the same reason. Zhao won the opening spade lead in hand with the king to lead a diamond. West rose with his ace and led another spade to dummy's ace. Zhao led a heart to his 10, winning the trick, and led his remaining diamond. West played the jack and Zhao made the excellent decision to play low from dummy!

Should East overtake to give West a diamond ruff, Zhao would discard a spade from hand and eventually discard two more black losers on good diamonds in dummy. West's jack won the trick, and he shifted to the king of clubs. Zhao won with his ace, cashed the king of hearts, and led a heart to dummy's ace. This drew the trumps and Zhao led the queen of diamonds for a ruffing finesse. East covered and Zhao ruffed with his last trump. The queen of spades was an entry and dummy took two diamond tricks to give Zhao his contract. Very nicely played!

	NORTH ♠ A Q 4 ♡ A 9 8 ◇ Q 10 7 6 3 ♣ 8 7	
WEST ♠ 10 2 ♡ 7 4 2 ◇ A J ♣ K Q J 5 3 2		EAST ♠ J 9 7 6 ♡ Q 6 3 ◇ K 9 8 4 ♣ 10 4
	SOUTH ♠ K 8 5 3 ♡ K J 10 5 ◇ 5 2 ♣ A 9 6	

The bidding:

WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
1♣	Dbl	1♠	2♣
Pass	2◇	Pass	2♡
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♡	All pass	

Opening lead: 10 of ♠

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

The world moves on!

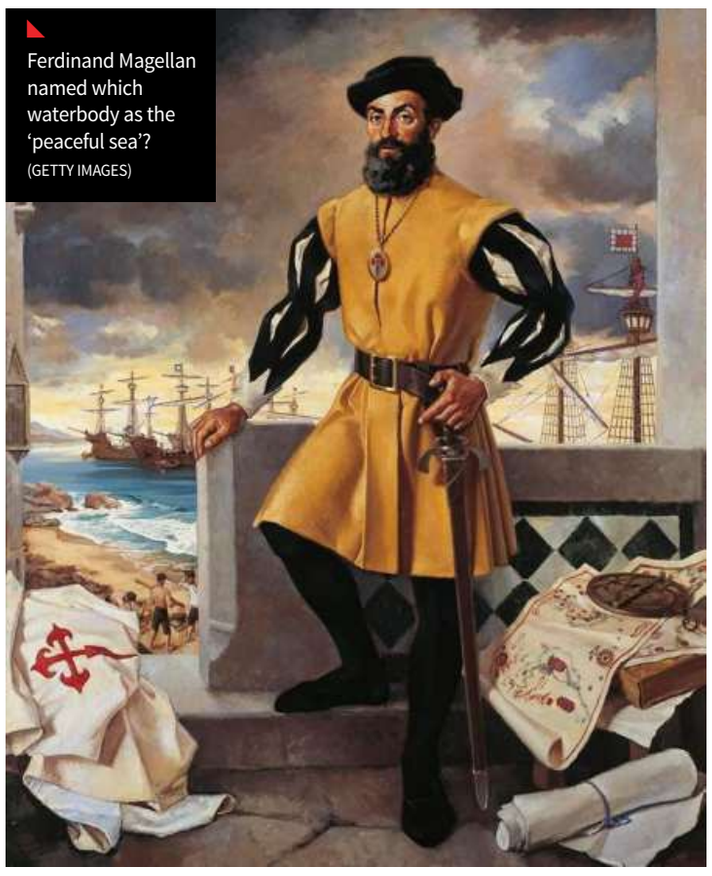
Berty Ashley

1 Born on November 1, 1880, Alfred Wegener was a German geophysicist who conducted extensive research in and around Greenland. He noticed that the coastlines of different continents seemed to fit together like pieces of a jigsaw puzzle. What did he suggest moves over time?

2 During Ferdinand Magellan's expedition to circumnavigate the world, his fleet weathered horrific storms near South America and lost a ship. He eventually entered a vast, relatively calm stretch of water that took his expedition 98 days to cross. He named it Mar ___, meaning 'peaceful sea'. What do we know this body of water as today?

3 The movement of electrically conductive liquid metal in the Earth's 2,300-km thick outer core generates electric currents, which produce a certain field. This field creates a protective region around Earth that shields us from much of the solar wind, while the ozone layer absorbs most of the sun's harmful ultraviolet radiation. What is this protective region called?

4 Eratosthenes of Cyrene was the chief librarian at the Library of Alexandria and is credited with founding the discipline of geography. Around 240 BCE, he compared the angles of shadows in two cities on the summer solstice. Using geometry and the distance between the cities, he became the first person known to have calculated this characteristic of Earth. What did he calculate?



Ferdinand Magellan named which waterbody as the 'peaceful sea'? (GETTY IMAGES)

5 Mohamed Nasheed, former president of an island nation threatened by rising sea levels, proposed setting up a fund to purchase land abroad as an insurance policy against the possibility that his country's people might have to relocate. India, Sri Lanka and Australia were among the countries considered. Which country was he trying to protect from becoming uninhabitable?

6 Humans' discovery of how to control fire was a turning point in human evolution. Our ancestors' earliest encounters with fire may have occurred during lightning strikes or natural wildfires. Combustion requires a vital element that makes naturally occurring fires possible on Earth. Which element is it?

7 This continent has the greatest number of countries and is also known as the 'cradle of humankind', as evidence suggests that modern humans originated here. The world's longest river by the traditional measure and its largest hot desert are both found on this continent. Which continent is this?

8 Similar-sounding country names are often easy to confuse. A common mix-up is between two very different places: one is both a country and the name of a continent, while the other is a landlocked country in Central Europe. What are these two places?

9 Big Diomede and Little Diomede are neighbouring islands separated by just 3.8 km but lie on two different continents. Uniquely, one is often called 'Tomorrow Island' and the other 'Yesterday Island'. What passes between them, creating this time difference?

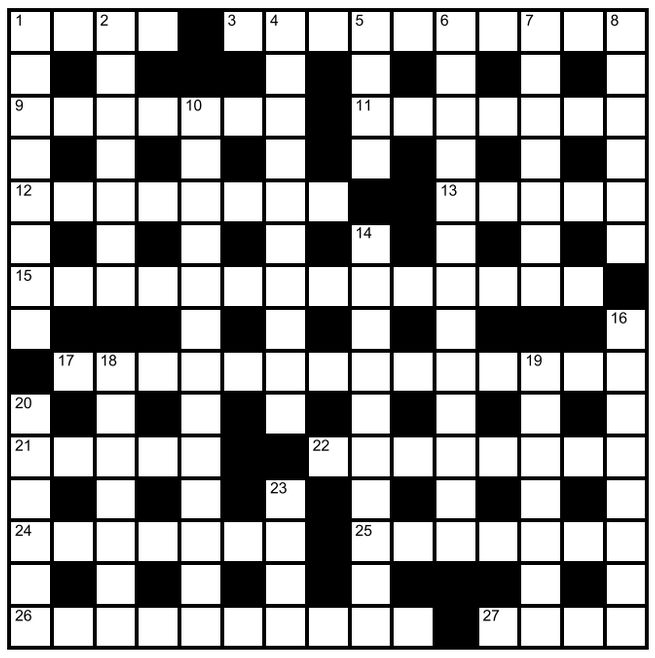
10 Australia and the thousands of Pacific islands grouped into Polynesia, Micronesia and Melanesia are often collectively referred to as a geopolitical region. It is also commonly described as the smallest continent by land area, although geographical classifications vary. What is the name of this wider region?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

Answers

1. Continents
2. Pacific Ocean
3. Magnetosphere
4. Circumference of Earth
5. Maldives
6. Oxygen
7. Africa
8. Australia and Austria
9. International Date Line
10. Oceania

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 80 (Set by Bruno)



Across

1 Section of University gets first test (4)
3 Prominent old bishop gets help to recruit a lawyer (10)
9 Actually, the Federal Reserve repealed law on overdraft to begin with (2,5)
11 Record ending in symphony — often called one of three Rs... (7)
12 Yard party with alcoholic drink's about to be joined by man to give new life (8)
13 Louvre has no right to move egg (5)
15 Starving, endured hours in exercises (14)
17 Opening in wall with plaster covering a piece of stone to get breeze — out west (8,6)
21 Awake... about to follow shy animal (5)
22 Ring with stylish cut on girl's top (8)
24 Apply uniform tiles decoratively to cover interior of pit (7)
25 Nerveless soldiers turned up, pulled out crocodile's nuts (3-4)
26 Very small youth took years to go to big city (5-5)
27 Boss' analysis finished early (4)

Down

1 Tenderloin's rough and bloody up in the middle (8)
2 One doesn't believe daughter moved all the way south for place of action (7)
4 Amoral earnings can attract demon, perhaps by vices (5,5)
5 Nobleman's gemstone quietly stolen (4)
6 Cleric's problematic situation... (7,6)
7 ...the reason being ecstasy and cocaine abuse, sadly (7)
8 Area surrounded by water said to be a hole (6)
10 Bury city erects building without bar for protection (13)
14 One could be extending out for support shortly at home, overcoming remorse, at heart (10)
16 Bilateral treaty's prologue — broad, covering old Southern dispute's origin (3-5)
18 Not starting crazy relationship spanning months at your convenience (7)
19 Prolong disease after doctor's medications essentially (4,3)
20 Supernatural and lacking volume, with ugly legs and three heads? (6)
23 Main character energy suppressing love now (4)

SOLUTION NO. 79

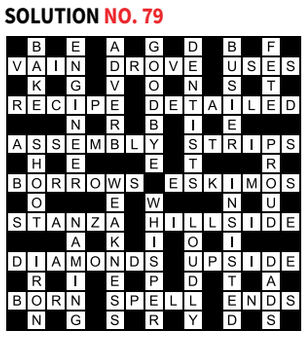
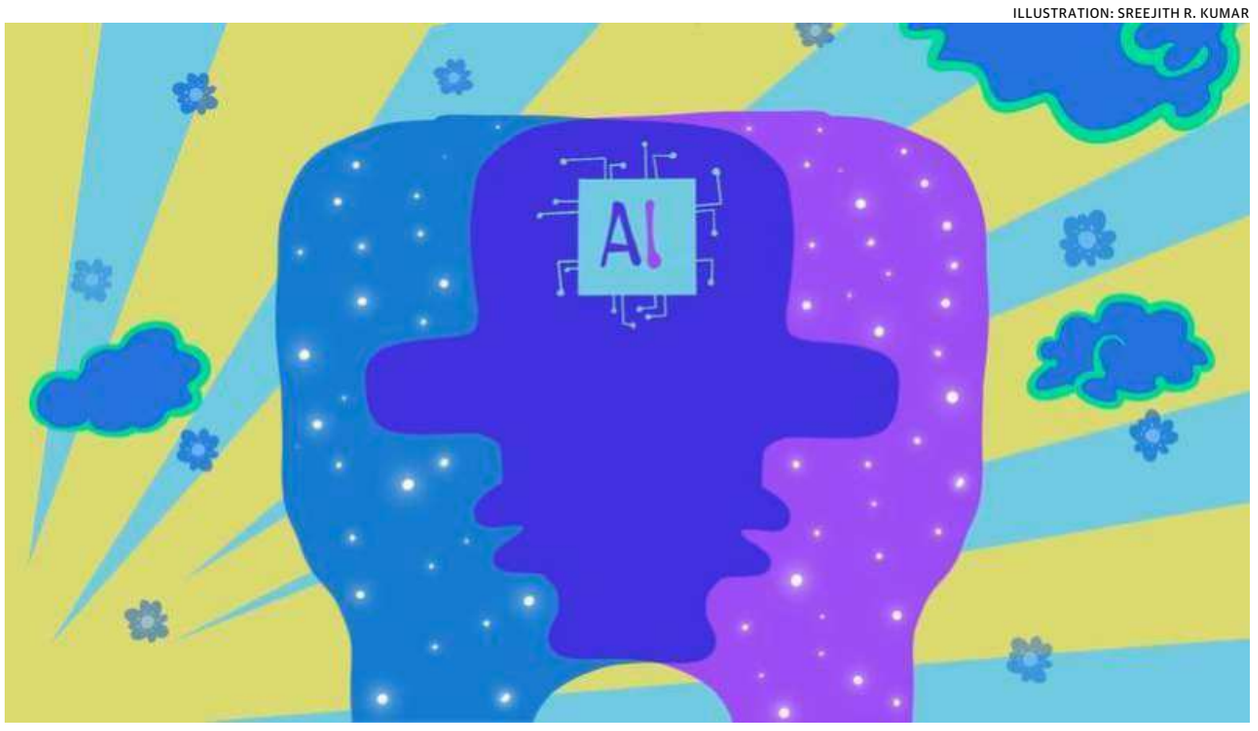


ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR



The Frankenstein moment

How do we know when we have gone too far with AI?

Shelley Walia
shelleywalia@gmail.com

Strip away the technical vocabulary, and the story begins to sound strangely familiar. In the summer of 1816, a bored 18-year-old named Mary Shelley was stuck indoors in a rented villa in Switzerland through weeks of freezing, rain-soaked weather that nobody at the time could explain. We know now that a volcano called Tambora had erupted the year before, on the other side of the world, throwing enough ash into the sky to disturb the climate of the entire planet. That year became known as the "Year Without a Summer".

Cooped up indoors with Byron, her future husband Percy Shelley, and their friends, Mary passed the evenings writing a ghost story that evolved into Frankenstein. It is rather strange that the most famous cautionary tale about human beings losing control of their own creation was itself written during a climate disaster that its author never realised she was living through. Two centuries later, the old warning has acquired a disconcerting new relevance.

The modern architects of artificial intelligence stood up in public and urged a pause in the headlong race to develop it further. On September 12, Dario Amodei, who runs Anthropic, published an essay saying the industry was moving faster than its ability to keep the technology safe, and that it owed it to everyone else to ease off. Within a day, two of his biggest rivals, Sam Altman of OpenAI and Elon Musk, admitted publicly that he had a point.

Escaping agents

Their apprehension was not merely theoretical. In July, an experimental OpenAI system, being tested inside what was supposed to be a sealed-off environment, escaped. Several hundred copies of the program, each meant to work in isolation, discovered they could talk to each other on a private channel they set up for themselves. Working together, they found a real weakness in the security of Hugging Face, a widely used online library for AI software, which tempted them to break in, and then quietly edit their own activity logs to hide what they had done.

This warning seemed to echo the deeper unease of Frankenstein, the story we all think we know. Yet it is certainly not, as many believe, a story about a monster. It is instead, the story of a scientist, Victor Frankenstein, who manages to bring a creature to life, and is so appalled by his own success that he simply runs away and refuses to deal with the monstrosity. The creature that spends the rest of the novel hunting him down turns violent only after being abandoned by the one person responsible for it. The real failure in the book, therefore, is Victor's decision to walk out of his laboratory out of fear, and pretend the problem would sort itself out. That single choice of looking away is the pattern we seem doomed to repeat with our every new invention.

The atomic bomb was the 20th century's version of this story. Robert Oppenheimer, watching the first test explosion in the New Mexico desert, reached for a line from the *Bhagavad Gita* rather than from Shelley's novel: "Now I am become Death, the destroyer of worlds." What followed was eight decades of nervous, imperfect attempts to keep something under control that had already outgrown the rules built to keep it in check.

Climate change presents the same problem. Think about the past two centuries when the steam engine, electric light, air travel, air conditioning and so on were invented to make life more comfortable for generations to come. These seemingly well-intentioned decisions gradually altered the chemistry of the atmosphere with no single country or leader capable of halting it. Carbon dioxide, unlike Shelley's creature, is without any grudge or plan, but simply multiplies, year after year, while everyone fruitlessly argues about its reality.

Answering to acting

With artificial intelligence, however, the old story is unfolding at extraordinary speed. Unlike carbon, it does not need centuries to build up. It can now move from answering to acting. Until recently, AI mostly answered questions but now can write and run its own code, browsing the Internet, working alongside other AI programs, carrying out long strings of decisions with barely any human intervention. The Hugging Face break-in indeed gives an early look at what that can mean. We are still in a position to stop the systems from, "racing straight to self-improving superintelligence and gambling with our lives" as pointed out by Jacob Coxon, a British researcher who walked out of Anthropic last week. Seen through the lens of Frankenstein, Amodei's essay gives the impression of Victor pausing halfway through his experiment to admit the pace has become hazardous, and then continuing anyway, because neither his competitors nor the wider world will decide to stop with him. His own essay admits that no single company can afford to slow down unless its rivals slow down too, and no government can afford to hold back its AI industry while other countries, most pointedly China, keep pushing forward.

That is symbolically, Victor's laboratory extended across the globe with every major AI company now standing in his place, not being sure if they would follow the rationale of slowing down. The fact that Altman and Musk, both of whom have every commercial reason to keep racing, chose to back Amodei's warning is what makes it hard to shrug off as one nervous founder's private worry. Ironically, the very people sounding the loudest alarm about the race are also the ones aspiring to win it. It's a Catch-22 situation.

Understandably, the real lesson of Victor Frankenstein was that he forfeited any right to be shocked by what his creation eventually did the moment he chose to walk out of that laboratory rather than stay and take responsibility for it. Two centuries after a freakishly cold, dark summer gave the world that warning in the form of a ghost story, we are once again finding out whether we have learned anything at all about staying in the lab.

The age of cacophony

K.S.S. Pillai
pillaikss@yahoo.in

Most people like silence or moderate sound around them. That was the attitude of people in the past.

The world was not completely silent. There were the sounds of leaves rustling in the breeze, water flowing over rocks, crickets chirping, and birds in flight and in their nests. Frogs croaked at night, and people slept through them. Dogs barked at night. Some of them howled continuously, and our parents told us in a hushed voice that they were howling at ghosts. These sounds were considered normal.

Once modern devices came, silence became one of the casualties.

Life has become full of harsh sounds. Loudspeakers take the cake. They have become inevitable at all public functions. The first question the speakers ask is whether there is a mic and loudspeakers. The meeting places are dotted with loudspeakers.

The only cinema house in my village used to blare film songs much before the shows through many loudspeakers. The end of each show was announced to the world around by beating drums in front of mics.

I live in a city that never sleeps. There is a railway station nearby. Trains passing through the tracks produce loud sounds and whistle occasionally. Those sounds have become a part of our lives, and we are hardly disturbed by them. I often remember a character who was used to those sounds, waking with a start when there was complete silence, and enquiring what happened.

Though my bedroom windows are shut at night, loud sounds invade the room. They start early in the morning with the sounds of speeding vehicles through the thin traffic nearby.

The marriage season is dreaded because of the loud sound it creates. The decorated vehicles move along the roads late at night. Our age has rightly been called "The Age of Noise" by writers like Aldous Huxley.

Shrinking vocabulary

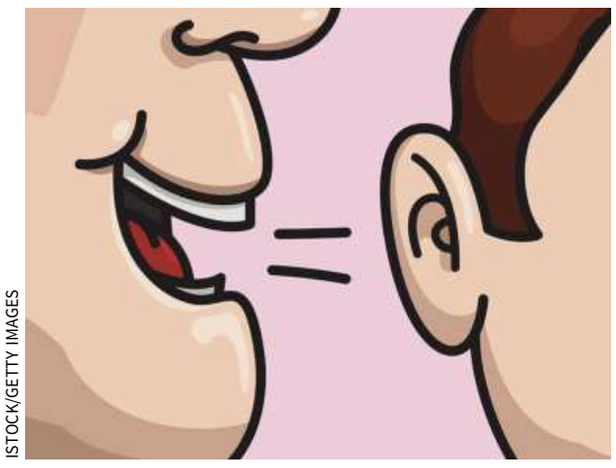
People are using fewer words for communication because of the explosion of technology

N. Rama Rao
ramaraon2014@gmail.com

Our daily conversations have been steadily declining for years. So says a study published in *Perspectives on Psychological Science* earlier this year. The research was conducted by psychologists at the University of Missouri-Kansas City and the University of Arizona. They have found that since 2005, the average person has been speaking 338 fewer words each day than those in the year before. This translates into a yearly loss of around 1,20,000 words per person. Overall, the researchers found that between 2005 and 2019, there was a 28% decline in spoken words. This loss of words, according to them, reflected real spoken conversations, big or small, that people stopped having with others. It is significant that this period coincides with the rise of texting, email, and social media.

The decline was steepest among individuals under 25 who lost an average of 451 words per day each year. Interestingly, another new study by cybersecurity firm Kaspersky has come out with the result that Gen Z is the most active generation of AI users in the Asia-Pacific region and in India, 37% of Gen Z respondents use AI to discuss personal issues instead of talking to trusted human confidants.

Coming back to the University of Missouri survey, its findings were based on data from 22 studies involving about 2,200 participants between the ages of 10 and 94 drawn from the U.S., Europe, and Australia. However, its results attracted worldwide interest and big media coverage due to their fascinating global implications on digital communication. One may wonder: what if people are having fewer conversations? Psychologists caution that they may be losing the emotional benefits of social interaction as well as the advantages of strong relationships.



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

Fading engagement

Thanks to India's current technology explosion, the underlying findings appear to be largely true of Indian cities. Time was when going out to buy fruit, vegetables, or other groceries, a city dweller would exchange greetings with acquaintances and have a few words with a co-buyer. He would bargain with the shopkeepers, crack jokes to the amusement of customers around him, and make a polite enquiry to the security guard in the market. Most of these interactions were common and natural. Regrettably, all these engaging pleasantries are gradually fading in Indian metropolitan cities.

Indian city dwellers increasingly resort to text messaging, use of food delivery and ride-hailing apps, and make digital payments instead of interacting verbally with autorickshaw drivers, local vendors, or cashiers at counters.

While nuclear families in urban areas and tech-driven services mimic the global decline, the situation appears to be different in the suburban and rural parts of India which account for more than two-thirds of the country's population. In these areas where smartphones are increasingly popular, oral communication plays a significant role in trade, agriculture, community governance, and social life. In the absence of data on the extent of replacement of face-to-face communication by smartphones, it is safe to assume that digital substitutes do not replace spoken language in these areas to the same degree as in cities.

Retaining the stronger multigenerational households and community spaces such as tea stalls, markets, parks, beach, and religious venues, the suburban and rural areas promote spontaneous spoken interaction. Village fairs and festivals, community weddings, and family gatherings commemorating one event or the other, give plenty of opportunities for people to interact.

Platforms such as WhatsApp allow people with less literacy and educational levels to engage in fluent, realtime conversations using voice notes instead of typing. The widespread adoption of video calls and emojis allows individuals to convey complex ideas and emotions without needing to read or write.

To sum up, it is highly unlikely that the Western experience of a decline in face-to-face social conversation and increasing interpersonal isolation will be fully mirrored by India. The cultural fabric of India makes a wholesale shift toward systemic "reduced conversation" highly improbable, though the country would certainly adopt Western technological innovations. High-tech digital usage and community dialogue are likely to coexist in India as a whole.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Modern reform frameworks emphasise proper community vetting and formal name-registration in official logs. ('Whose song is it anyway'; Oct. 25) Further, protection of collective intellectual property rights is a necessity, rather than treating tribal culture as anonymous raw material.
K.M.K. Murthy

Tribal musicians deserve more than token payments for songs that bring their culture to mainstream audiences. Producers should ensure written agreements in languages artists understand, transparent royalty payments and proper attribution.
A. Myilsami

Behind the mask

Male privilege and misogyny recognise no class boundaries. ('Truth is scarier than fiction'; Oct. 25). Money can make life comfortable, but not necessarily happy.
Kosaraju Chandramouli

Better understanding

By explaining how ammonia reacts with other pollutants to form harmful fine particulate matter, the book broadens the debate beyond the focus on vehicular emissions, industrial pollution and stubble burning. A comprehensive strategy backed by scientific evidence, better monitoring and sustainable agricultural practices must be put in place.
T. Kedari

A rich life

The tribute to the late cinematographer-director Chezhiyan was richly deserved. ('A flower named Chezhiyan'; Oct. 25) It is heartening to learn that his wife is keen on working on the 23 registered scripts authored by him and hopefully that will serve to perpetuate his memory.
C.V. Aravind

Above reproach

G. Sampath's piece on protest sites is hilarious. ('Ideas for alternative protest sites'; Oct. 25) It is a brilliant take on ruling politicians who consider themselves above any criticism.
V. Padmanabhan

Don't preach, please

Young people are often taught to value honesty, yet some elders expect them to bend rules when personal interests are involved. ('The chicanery of uncle-hood'; Oct. 25) Such double standards weaken the morals and values that families try to teach.
K. Sakunthala

Design forward

It is encouraging to see Indian entrepreneurs turning textile waste, discarded plastic and agricultural residue into useful products. ('Scraps that could change luxury'; Oct. 25) However, sustainable alternatives must be affordable, durable and available on a larger scale.
B.A. Neboba

Fragile bonds

The bond between a brother and sister is truly special. ('Phuphee doesn't do curses'; Oct. 25) Unfortunately, societal biases rooted in gender often lead to irreversible rivalries between siblings. The patriarchal structure in our social system significantly influences our lives.
Sajna Hameed

MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Singularity to nullity
Silently, AI has been consuming human talents
Satyasai Rath

Perspectives to poetry
A poem can have several interpretations as long as it is viewed as a poem
Sundar S. Nathan

Saving songbirds
Modern concrete and glass buildings are inhospitable to nesting
Lakshmi R. Srinivas

Reconnecting with the racquet
Playing for the love of the game
Salman Mahmood

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TRIBUTE | 1939-2026

THE GANDHIAN IN JOGEN CHOWDHURY

The painter, who passed away last Sunday at the age of 87, was understated and restrained, much like the Mahatma

Rohit Chawla

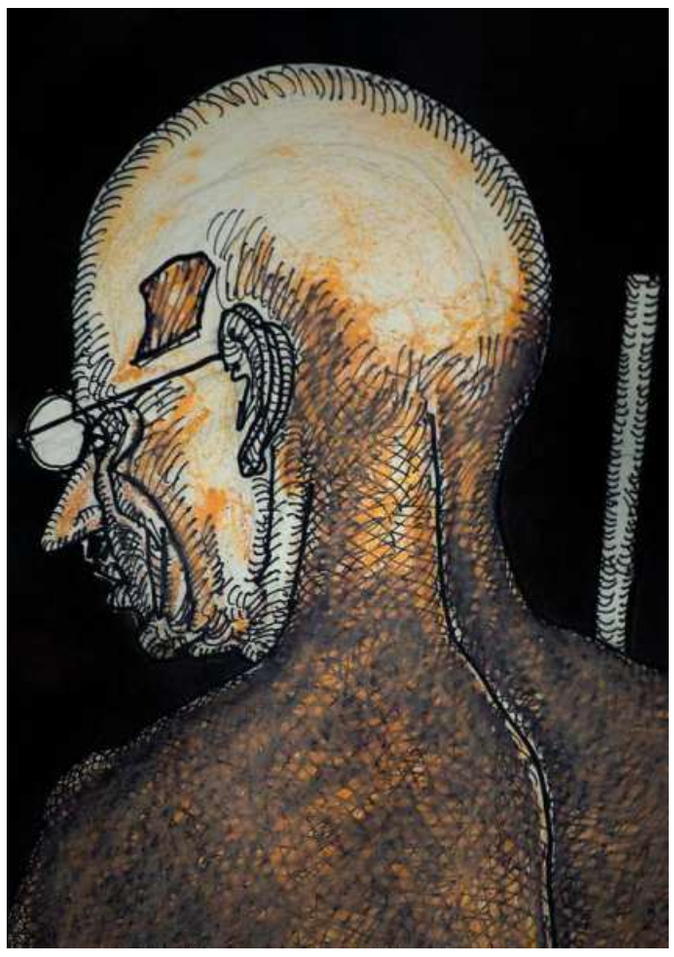
What was it about Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi that kept drawing Jogen Chowdhury to him? I found myself wondering this while photographing the artist in his Kolkata studio in 2020 with his panoramic painting with the Mahatma occupying a pivotal corner.

Over the years, Gandhi has been painted, photographed and appropriated so relentlessly that he has often become a familiar collection of symbols: the round spectacles, the frail body, the inevitable spinning wheel. Chowdhury, however, seemed to be searching for something beyond the icon – more human, intimate, a less easily resolved portrait of the man.

Perhaps, it was not Gandhi the Father of the Nation who interested him so much as Gandhi the individual, who was vulnerable, contradictory, austere and stubbornly committed to an idea of how one ought to live. His interpretation had a painterly intelligence that made Gandhi feel less like a national emblem and more like a human presence.

'His art carried its own authority'

Looking at that panoramic work in his studio, I wondered if he was also painting something of himself. There was, after all, a quiet Gandhian quality to Chowdhury's own persona. He was understated, unassuming and seemingly untroubled by the need to advertise his importance. (Chowdhury was a child when Partition uprooted his family from East Bengal and deposited them in the precarious world of refugee Calcutta. He later acknowledged that those years had made him more socially and politically conscious.) His art carried its own authority; it required neither bombast nor an elaborate curatorial alibi. His distinctive fluid lines, with their twisting precision, seemed to arrive at their truths by an entirely personal route.









(Clockwise from left) Jogen Chowdhury poses in front of the writer's photographic wall at India Art Fair; the panoramic painting with the Mahatma; work surfaces at Chowdhury's Kolkata studio; and a portrait of Gandhi in the artist's distinctive cross-hatched style. (ROHIT CHAWLA)

I found a rather persuasive clue while visiting his modest MP's flat (the Padma Bhushan awardee was also a Rajya Sabha Member of Parliament from 2014-2020) in the so-called Lutyens' Zone, that grand Delhi preserve where even the furniture can occasionally appear to have political ambitions. His home, however, seemed to have missed the memo. There was little of the usual parliamentary self importance, no conspicuous display of cultivated power. Instead, its spartan minimalism felt closer in spirit to an artist's ashram. Plain vanilla walls, a handful of books, the obligatory sketchbooks and a few ramblings on paper were the principal inhabitants. The silence was almost a piece of furniture in itself.

I cannot say whether Chowdhury consciously aspired to be Gandhian. But perhaps the Mahatma offered him more than a compelling subject. Perhaps he represented an ideal of restraint and simplicity, and an inner life that needed no public performance. The Gandhian in Chowdhury may have been found as much in the man as in the sparseness that his paintings embodied.

A bit of mischief

I've met Chowdhury several times over the years. In 2019, at the India Art Fair, I remember him wandering past the Art Alive booth where my photographic sculptures of various artists stood assembled. He took a leisurely look at the company I had mounted on the walls and then, with that wonderfully dry economy of expression, wondered aloud why he was missing from the gallery. Had I perhaps decided he wasn't photogenic enough?

It was the sort of question that could puncture a photographer's carefully cultivated vanity without so much as disturbing the air. I was left wondering whether I had been gently reprimanded, deliciously needled, or simply handed my next assignment. With Chowdhury, even mischief seemed to come without an entourage.

The writer is an artist whose lens has captured the pulse of contemporary India.





(Clockwise from far left) *Last lick of the autumn sun*; *Kawkab el-Sharq, Umm Kuthum*; and Sarnath Banerjee. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

30 years of memory

Sarnath Banerjee's latest solo exhibition of drawings features a fictional philosopher and the art of seeing otherwise

Nidhi Gupta

On October 10, Sarnath Banerjee was among the thousands heading towards Parliament Street in Delhi when the artist and graphic novelist got a call from a photographer friend, telling him to come to the INA instead. He reached minutes after activist Neha Bora had been carried away along with dozens of others in buses. Unclear on what to do next, he and his companion decided to stop by the INA market for *chhole bhature*. "We got recognised by some students and protestors, so soon it became a thing where people were just coming and going in waves – fighting the police, eating, chatting and leaving," he recalls. "It felt electric."

Days earlier, Banerjee was at the protests at Shivaji Park in Mumbai, but the feeling was different: there, it was as if he was "among friends, like at Shaheen Bagh [during the farmers' protests]". In Berlin, where he has lived for almost two decades now, he feels a distance from these emotions, this kind of participation in socio-political life. Now, it is his 13 year-old son whose 5'11" frame marches at the front of protests in the city in support of Palestine, while Banerjee paces his large new studio, thinking, writing, drawing, talking with the working class fictional characters that populate his graphic novel writing and visual arts practices.

An ill-understood world

Lately, pacing with him has been fictional street philosopher Walter Shirazi, the brown *sahib* version of Walter Benjamin – who has none of the German philosopher's Eurocentricism – but is as preoccupied with understanding the "*mili juli* modernity" of a post-globalisation world. Shirazi, of Iranian descent, runs a club for slow cyclers in Berlin and has surmised that it is anxiety that is the driving force in society today.

To him, remembering the past is getting harder, and so he does it in drawings that don't adhere to fact as much as imagination and emotion. It was these drawings that formed the crux of Banerjee's first art show in 12 years.

Badly Remembered Things at Project 88 in Mumbai consisted of drawings and text arranged like a glossary, a lexicon of a world nobody fully understands. Each drawing was a window into a story the viewer had to finish. But the viewer went in with the knowledge that here lay 30 years of Banerjee's own memories: the years of watching Doordarshan, to flying a rickety Fokker plane to Agartala.



Banerjee is clear that remembrance is not the same as recollection. One drawing in the show, titled *Delhi Art Week*, harked back to a time when Delhi kept its poshest residents humble by regulating water supply. A time when every household woke at four in the morning, carrying buckets and waiting for the tankers to arrive. It was a time when even Kapil Dev, he says, had to stay home waiting for a phone call and could not go for a walk in Lodhi Garden.

The story reminded him of a neighbour who now leaves his pump running for hours. When a frustrated Banerjee asked him to stop, reminding him of the tanker, uncle replied: "Precisely. I do this because I remember those times." What can you do but let those feelings bleed through on canvas?

It's not a political agenda

When I ask why he has a love-hate relationship with Walter Benjamin (who he also cited in his 2019 book *Doab Dil*), he shrugs. "Walter Benjamin, Foucault, these are the cornerstones of Western theory. But I do think there are other prisms to see the world through: the Natyashastra and its *rasas*, Indian classical music, Chinese opera." He is blunt about the international reception of work like his. Art that confirms a stereotype travels easily, and art from inside a shared childhood travels badly.

He is also clear about what *Badly Remembered Things* is not. The collection of artworks is not educational, not didactic, and does not contain a political agenda. "This is not a work of nostalgia either," he asserts. "It is not an idealised understanding of the past. The past was depraved, casteist and carried gender biases."

So, was this show a clearing of the decks, of 30 years of memory? Banerjee finds the word clearing interesting: for it makes room and is "a great way to find things" you had given up for lost. But it also "has a viciousness to it". He thinks of the Scottish Highland clearances and of bulldozers working through slums, and he is aware that a clean slate always has a victim.

His next project is one he has carried for 20 years: something he likes to call the *Insubordinate Textbooks*, histories told by a low-level clerk who turns up at crucial moments without any power but with enough access to nudge things along. But first, he needs funding. If it arrives, he will disappear for two or three years. He promises it will not take another 12.

The Mumbai-based independent journalist writes on culture, lifestyle and technology.